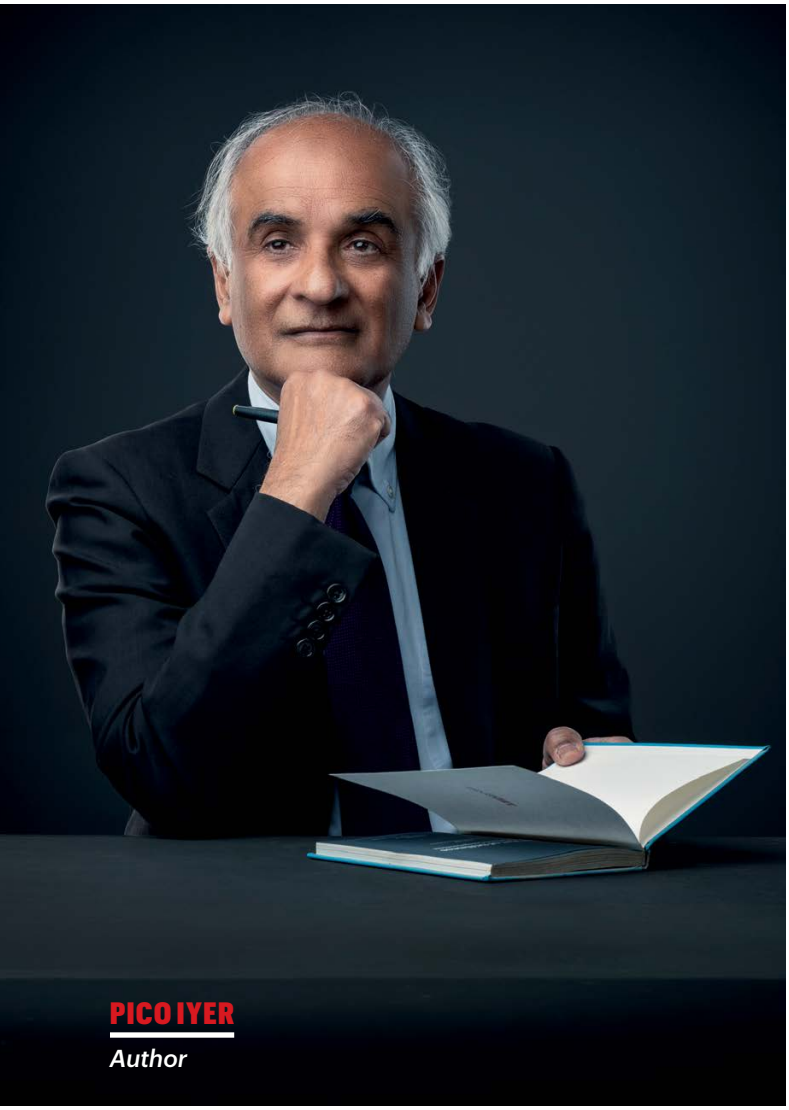
YOU CAN'T OUTSOURCE HUMANITY TO AI



PICO IYER
Author

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

At a time when nations are at war with each other, and people are divided by their words and beliefs, what better than to savour moments of stillness and reclaim our inner world? And who better than Pico Iyer, a former journalist and now a celebrated writer, constant traveller, regular presence at TED talks, and in his most recent avatar, an actor—in Josh Safdie's table tennis drama, *Marty Supreme*—to guide us on that journey? He did not disappoint, with a treasure trove of insights on how to find inner peace when our outer world seems to be disintegrating.

Iyer is an ardent practitioner of solitude, retreating to a Benedictine monastery in Big Sur, California, every year even though he is not a Christian; setting up home in suburban Nara in Japan with his wife Hiroko Takeuchi, and stubbornly refusing to keep a cellphone, since, he says, "I don't want my attention to be cut up into a thousand fragments." And while his readers see a frequent traveller in his writings, for Iyer, that is just the tip of the iceberg. "They see the 20 per cent that's travel, not the 80 per cent that is sitting in one place."

"Travel is akin to going to a market—you gather herbs, spices, veggies, but you can make a meal only by staying in one place in the kitchen

Over history, humans have altered technology much more than technology has altered humans

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Stillness, even when enforced, is not an unqualified tragedy. So much of our great books, by Nehru or Mandela, came while they were imprisoned**
- **Technology has given us everything except a wise and discerning sense of how to use it. We can't outsource our humanity and wisdom to it**
- **Spend 20 minutes every morning just being quiet. It may be 3 per cent of your waking hours, but it transforms the other 97 per cent**
- **We must make decisions that ensure that we're not caught up in the moments of this week...that make us blind to the larger arc**